

## Executive Summary

The **PSB's Cybersecurity, Fraud & Artificial Intelligence Hackathon 2026** is a national-level innovation contest hosted by the Bank of India (BOI) in collaboration with IIT Hyderabad, under the aegis of the Government of India's Department of Financial Services (DFS, Ministry of Finance) and coordinated by the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) <sup>1</sup> <sup>2</sup>. It challenges students and young entrepreneurs to develop AI/ML solutions to real-world banking problems in cybersecurity and fraud. Registration opens on **7 May 2026** and closes on **15 June 2026**, with teams (3–4 members each) submitting an initial project proposal (solution approach) by the deadline <sup>3</sup> <sup>4</sup>. After a two-stage selection process (online shortlisting and prototype development), up to 50 finalist teams are invited to present their working prototypes on **27–28 August 2026** at IIT Hyderabad (travel and lodging support is provided for outstation finalists <sup>5</sup>). A total prize pool of ₹20 lakhs (₹10 lakhs per problem track) is split across first (₹5L), second (₹3L) and third (₹2L) prizes for each topic <sup>6</sup>. Prize money is disbursed in three installments (50% at finale, 30% post-Global FinTech Fest 2026, 20% on product completion) <sup>7</sup>. The winning team in each track earns national recognition (including an invitation to present at GFF 2026 <sup>8</sup>) and certificates for all participants.

This report presents a detailed breakdown of the event, including its organisation, rules, themes, deliverables, evaluation, timeline, and practical advice for participants. It draws primarily on the official hackathon website and related announcements <sup>1</sup> <sup>4</sup>, supplemented by press releases from a similar 2025 BOI-IITH hackathon <sup>9</sup> <sup>10</sup> and government sources <sup>2</sup>.

## Event Overview and Organisers

This hackathon is part of the **PSBs Hackathon Series 2026**, a government-backed initiative to foster innovation in the public banking sector <sup>2</sup> <sup>11</sup>. The event is **organized by the Bank of India**, in **collaboration with IIT Hyderabad**, and is *powered by* the Department of Financial Services (Ministry of Finance) and coordinated by the Indian Banks' Association <sup>1</sup>. BOI provides funding and domain guidance, while IITH hosts the event (including the final round on campus). The DFS/IBA support ensures alignment with national financial inclusion and cybersecurity goals <sup>2</sup> <sup>11</sup>. No additional corporate "sponsors" are listed; rather, the hackathon is an industry-academia program rather than a privately sponsored competition.

**Dates & Format:** Online registration and idea submission run from **7 May to 15 June 2026** <sup>4</sup>. Shortlisted teams are announced by 30 June, then prototype development continues through mid-August. Final live presentations and demo days are held on **27–28 August 2026** at IIT Hyderabad <sup>4</sup>. Thus, the hackathon is largely **hybrid**: initial phases (proposal submission, shortlisting) are conducted remotely, while the grand finale is an **onsite** event. Finalists travel to IITH (Hyderabad), with train fares (AC 3-tier) and accommodation provided for non-local participants <sup>5</sup>. (Note: There is no registration fee; participants register freely via the official website.)

## Registration Process and Deadlines

Interested teams register on the official website by filling out an online form <sup>12</sup> <sup>13</sup>. The form collects team details (name, members, institution, year, gender, etc.), contact info, and requires upload of a government-issued ID (PDF, ≤1 MB). Participants select *one* of the two problem statements and **upload**

a **brief solution approach PDF** ( $\leq 1$  MB) that describes the data sets to be used and the intended methodology <sup>13</sup>. The submission must outline the problem interpretation and high-level plan (not full code). An optional “recent projects” field allows teams to highlight prior work (1000 characters). Registration closes on **15 June 2026** (with resubmissions allowed up to that date) <sup>4</sup>. The organizers specify “no late entries,” so teams must meet the deadline <sup>4</sup>.

**Team Composition:** Each team must have **3–4 members** (teams of 2 are allowed by the form but the guidelines emphasize 3–4) <sup>3</sup>. Participants can be undergraduate/graduate students from any Indian university or institute. Unusually, the hackathon also welcomes young entrepreneurs, startup founders, and even dropouts or non-students <sup>3</sup>. As a women-empowerment measure, *at least one team member should be female if possible* <sup>3</sup> <sup>14</sup>. Individuals may register solo as well, but must indicate “Individual” participation on the form. Each team must nominate a team leader for communication.

## Hackathon Themes and Problem Statements

The hackathon focuses on *cybersecurity, fraud detection, and AI/ML in banking*. Participants must choose one of **two problem statements** when registering <sup>15</sup>. The official titles (slightly abridged) are:

- **Problem 1:** “*Harnessing Generative AI for Automated Reverse Engineering, Static and Dynamic Analysis, and Risk Scoring of Fraudulent Mobile Applications (APKs) and Malware.*” (Focus: use AI techniques to analyze Android APKs and detect malicious/fraudulent mobile apps) <sup>16</sup>.
- **Problem 2:** “*Develop an AI/ML solution to detect suspicious transactions and mule accounts by ingesting financial transaction data and alerts (fraud monitoring system alerts, government cyber-fraud alerts, etc.), and prevent the circulation of fraudulent proceeds through mule accounts. The solution should consume real-time regulatory feeds and cross-channel bank data.*” (Focus: use transaction data and alerts to flag fraud chains and mule accounts) <sup>17</sup>.

These problems target banking fraud: the first on malware in banking apps, the second on transaction-based money laundering. (For Statement 2, a sample dataset is provided on the portal.) Each problem is quite open-ended: for example, teams might build deep-learning models to reverse-engineer or sandbox-determine malicious APKs, or graph/ML models to identify fraudulent account networks. Solutions should be data-driven and practically applicable.

## Eligibility & Participation Rules

**Eligibility:** As noted, the hackathon is open to individuals and teams with members from any recognised Indian institute or university, plus young professionals/entrepreneurs in tech/finance. There is no citizenship restriction mentioned beyond being in India. All participants must be at least 18 years old (implied by ID requirement) and are expected to present government ID. The only quotas are *gender encouragement*: teams are asked to include women participants for diversity <sup>3</sup> <sup>18</sup>.

**Team Rules:** Teams register together (the online form collects the team name and member list). Only one registration per person. The guidelines expressly forbid plagiarism or duplicate submissions: “Solutions or ideas proposed must be unique & plagiarism is strictly prohibited” <sup>19</sup>. If identical solutions are submitted by multiple teams, those entries risk disqualification. All collaborators must be named and must submit through one team (no “ghost” external help). The organizing committee’s decisions on eligibility or rule breaches are final <sup>20</sup>.

## Technical and Non-Technical Requirements

The hackathon problems are technically demanding. **Technical requirements** (implied, not all stated explicitly) include proficiency in programming (e.g. Python/Java/C++), machine learning (especially deep learning, anomaly detection), cybersecurity tools, and data analytics. For Problem 1, skills in reverse engineering (APK unpacking, static analysis tools, dynamic analysis/sandboxing, and generative AI methods) would be needed. For Problem 2, teams will need to handle large-scale transaction datasets, possibly combining graph analysis (to find mule networks) and real-time alert feeds; so experience with ML pipelines, streaming data, and domain knowledge of fraud detection is key. Teams might use standard libraries (e.g. TensorFlow/PyTorch, Scikit-learn), and tools for Android analysis (e.g. static analyzers, sandboxes).

**Non-technical requirements:** Participants should be prepared to articulate business value – how their solution impacts banking operations or customer safety. **Teams should have members with complementary skills:** for instance, **one or two coders**, **one person focusing on banking domain**, and **one on presentation/coordination**. Reliable Internet access is needed to submit entries and for remote work. No prior project submissions are required, **but having a project or GitHub portfolio can strengthen the submission** (the form asks for “details of some recent project”<sup>21</sup>). A strong internet-connected laptop is likely needed for the finals (for demoing prototypes). Participants must comply with IIT Hyderabad campus rules during on-site final rounds, and sign a disclaimer (no liability for accidents or COVID-19, etc.)<sup>22</sup>.

## Submission Deliverables and Format

Submissions occur in two stages:

- **Initial Idea Submission (by 15 June 2026):** Teams submit the online form with personal details and **one or more chosen problem statements**<sup>23</sup>. Crucially, they must upload a **Solution Approach document** as a PDF ( $\leq 1$  MB)<sup>13</sup>. This document should include a detailed description of:
  - the dataset(s) to be used (e.g. sources or formats of transaction data, APK samples, alerts, etc.),
  - the proposed technical approach (algorithms, models, system design), and
  - any assumptions or validation plan.(The hackathon portal hints that topic details are given in an attached **Topic.pdf** and a sample **DataSet.csv** for Problem 2, which teams should use.)  
The PDF should be concise but clear; no code is required at this stage. (The online form also prompts for any relevant “recent project” and ID proof.)
- **Progress Report (due 17 Aug 2026):** **All teams that advance past shortlisting must develop a working prototype. By 17 August, each team must submit a short progress report (likely via email or portal).** While the exact format isn’t given, it presumably includes a status update on development, preliminary results (screenshots or metrics), and any changes to approach. Failure to submit this report by 17 Aug leads to disqualification<sup>24</sup>. This step ensures teams remain active and allows mentors/judges to track work-in-progress.
- **Final Presentation & Demo (27–28 Aug 2026):** Shortlisted finalists (about 50 teams) present in person at IIT Hyderabad. Each team typically has a demo slot (e.g. 5–10 minutes) to showcase their live prototype and slides. They must hand in a final presentation or code summary as per

instructions at the venue. (Any additional materials or code submissions would be specified during the event; not detailed in the public materials.)

In summary, the key deliverables are:

| Stage<br>Deadline                     | Deliverable                                 | Format              |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Registration/Idea<br>15 Jun 2026      | Solution approach PDF ( $\leq 1\text{MB}$ ) | PDF                 |
| Shortlisting<br>Late June 2026        | (No deliverable; selection)                 | n/a                 |
| Prototype Development<br>17 Aug 2026  | Progress report (update)                    | PDF (unspecified)   |
| Final Demo<br>27–28 Aug 2026 (onsite) | Working prototype + slides                  | Demo & Presentation |

Table: Submission deliverables (based on official requirements <sup>13</sup> <sup>24</sup>).

No official “templates” are provided publicly. Teams should format their documents clearly and follow any guidelines in the registration manual (mentioned but not publicly visible). The initial proposal must fit within 1 MB, so it should focus on high-level design, not full code dumps.

## Judging Criteria and Scoring Rubric

Although the organizers have not published a detailed rubric, industry precedent suggests entries will be judged on a mix of **innovation, technical strength, feasibility, and presentation**. In a previous BOI–IITH hackathon (FinShield 2025), solutions were evaluated on “innovation, technical feasibility, business potential, scalability and user experience” <sup>10</sup>. We infer similar criteria here. An illustrative rubric might include:

| Criterion                           | Focus                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Innovation &amp; Originality</b> | Novelty of approach, creative use of AI/ML, how well the idea goes beyond existing solutions <sup>10</sup> .                                   |
| <b>Technical Feasibility</b>        | Correctness and soundness of algorithms, technical depth, implementation quality (e.g. accuracy in detecting fraud) <sup>10</sup> .            |
| <b>Business/Impact Potential</b>    | Demonstrated potential to address real banking problems, clarity of use-case and benefits (e.g. reduced fraud losses) <sup>10</sup> .          |
| <b>Scalability &amp; Robustness</b> | Ability to handle large data volumes, adaptability across channels, and realistic deployment considerations <sup>10</sup> .                    |
| <b>Presentation &amp; UX</b>        | Clarity of the demo and slides, communication of ideas, team responsiveness to questions (judges often note user-friendliness) <sup>10</sup> . |

Table: Indicative judging criteria (as suggested by past hackathons <sup>10</sup>).

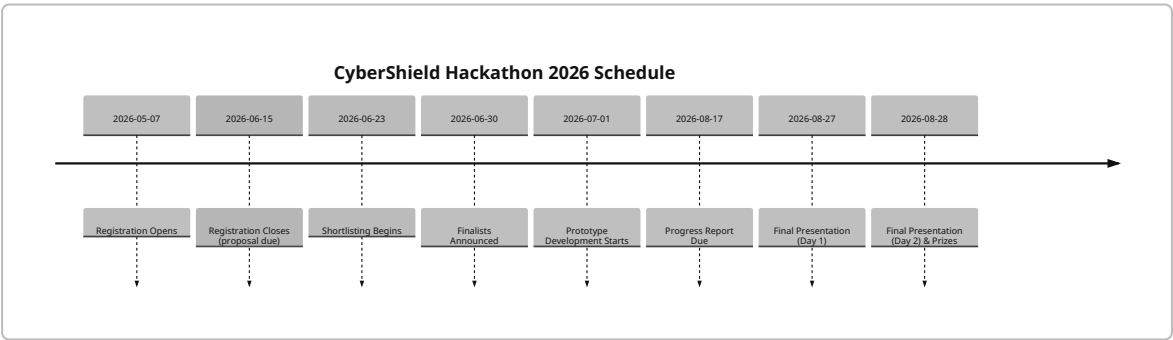
We expect judges (likely a mix of banking executives, technology experts, and academics) will allocate points in each category. High scores will go to teams that balance **novelty with practicality** – for example, an **AI model must not only be accurate but also interpretable and implementable in a bank setting**. Since exact scoring weights are unpublished, teams should aim to excel across all categories: craft a sound, innovative solution and present it clearly.

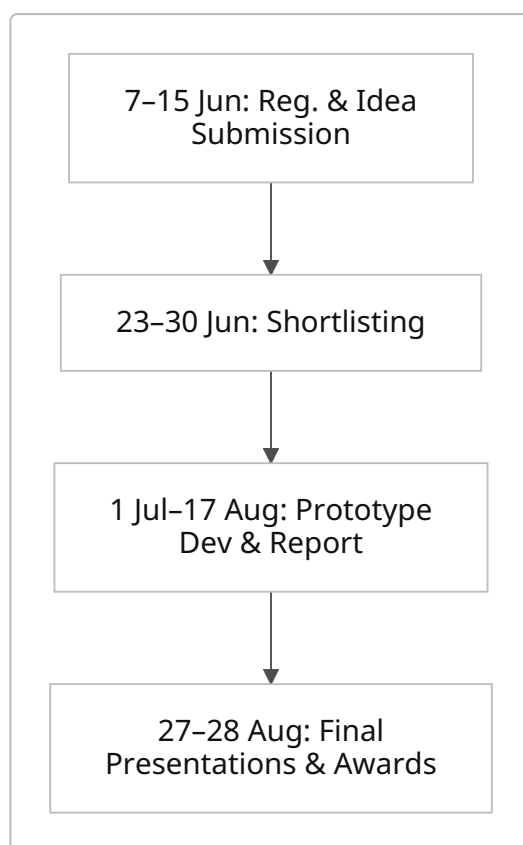
At the finale, judges typically ask pointed questions, so be prepared to explain technical choices, data sources, and potential deployment plans. (In FinShield 2025, judges from BOI and IBA explicitly praised AI/ML rigor and end-user impact <sup>10</sup>.)

### Timeline of Events

The event proceeds in several phases (dates from official announcement <sup>4</sup>). The table and timeline below summarise the key milestones:

| Phase                            | Dates (2026)           | Activity                                                                           |
|----------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Registration & Idea Submission   | 7 May – 15 June        | Teams register and submit solution approach PDF <sup>4</sup> .                     |
| Shortlisting (Phase 1)           | 23 – 30 June           | Organisers review submissions; ~70 teams are shortlisted <sup>25</sup> .           |
| Finalists Announced              | 30 June                | Top teams (≈50) are notified by email <sup>26</sup> .                              |
| Prototype Development (Phase 2)  | 1 July – 17 August     | Shortlisted teams build prototypes; progress reports due by 17 Aug <sup>24</sup> . |
| Final Presentations (Finale)     | 27 – 28 August         | Finalists present demos at IIT Hyderabad; winners announced <sup>4</sup> .         |
| Global FinTech Fest (post-event) | (TBA, likely Oct 2026) | Top team invited to present at GFF 2026 <sup>8</sup> .                             |





Figures: Chronological timeline and process flowchart for the hackathon (dates and phases from <sup>4</sup> <sup>24</sup> ).

## Prizes and Recognition

The total prize pool is **₹20 lakh per track (₹10L per problem)**, distributed as follows <sup>6</sup> : for *each* problem statement, 1st prize is ₹5,00,000, 2nd is ₹3,00,000, and 3rd is ₹2,00,000 <sup>6</sup> . These amounts are disbursed in **three installments** to encourage continued development: 50% at the grand finale, 30% after the Global FinTech Fest (GFF 2026), and 20% on successful product completion <sup>7</sup> . **Aside from cash, winners receive national recognition at the closing ceremony and certificates of excellence;** all participants earn participation certificates.

A unique award is the **invitation to GFF 2026** (India's Global FinTech Fest): the first-prize team in each track is guaranteed a slot to present at GFF, and the bank may invite the 2nd/3rd teams as well <sup>8</sup> . (Travel to GFF is arranged by the bank.) **Being showcased at GFF is a prestige opportunity linking winners with industry and investors.**

| Prize     | Amount (₹) | Payment Schedule                                              |
|-----------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1st Prize | 5,00,000   | 50% on finale, 30% at GFF, 20% after development <sup>7</sup> |
| 2nd Prize | 3,00,000   | (Same installment schedule)                                   |
| 3rd Prize | 2,00,000   | (Same installment schedule)                                   |

Table: Prize structure per problem statement (₹10 Lakh total per problem, following installments <sup>7</sup> <sup>6</sup> ).

## Mentorship and Workshops

The official announcements do **not explicitly list formal mentorship programs or workshops** for this hackathon. It appears teams work largely independently under the guidance of the IITH organizing committee. However, some support is likely: IIT Hyderabad may provide mentor assistance (faculty or alumni) informally to finalists, as is common in campus hackathons. Past IITH hackathons often feature on-site mentors during the development phase (though no mention is made here). Participants should monitor official communications (email/groups) for any announced webinars or Q&A sessions. In any case, teams can reach out to the provided contact (boihackathon@cse.iith.ac.in) for clarifications.

## Partner Roles and Sponsorship

- **Bank of India (BOI):** Main host and financier. BOI defined the challenge statements (in line with its cybersecurity/fraud priorities) and funds the prize pool. It also handles logistics for prize distribution, travel reimbursements, and may facilitate subsequent development (BOI officials judged the 2025 hackathon <sup>10</sup>).
- **IIT Hyderabad (IITH):** Technical and logistical partner. IITH (CSE Dept) operates the registration portal, shortlisting, and on-site event. It provides the venue (classrooms/labs at IITH) and administers travel reimbursements per its policies <sup>5</sup>. The IITH team (Prof. Sobhan Babu et al.) organizes committees and may vet project feasibility.
- **Department of Financial Services (DFS):** Funding and promotion. DFS launched the PSB hackathon series to drive innovation in public banks <sup>2</sup>, so it provides the overarching framework (including inviting PSBs to set problems). DFS and IBA logos appear on materials, indicating support. They do not run the hackathon day-to-day but lend credibility and outreach (e.g. possibly through press releases).
- **Indian Banks' Association (IBA):** Coordinating body. IBA likely helped BOI in structuring the hackathon (as with other PSB hackathons). Officials from IBA participate (IITH press noted IBA support in 2025 <sup>27</sup>).
- **Others:** No external commercial sponsors are listed. (In 2025's FinShield, IDRBT and others were involved, but for 2026 hackathon no additional sponsor is announced.)

## Intellectual Property & Data Privacy

According to the rules, **all intellectual property (IP) and code developed during the hackathon are jointly owned by Bank of India and IIT Hyderabad** <sup>28</sup>. **In practice, this means participants do not retain sole IP rights; any patentable or proprietary innovation created during the hackathon would be co-owned or transferred as per BOI/IITH policies.** Participants should plan accordingly (typically, hackathon solutions stay as prototypes and BOI may further develop them).

**Data privacy:** The hackathon likely provides datasets (especially for Problem 2) that are anonymized and safe to use. Teams should treat any sample data as confidential and not disclose sensitive information publicly. No personal customer data is expected to be provided. However, when handling external datasets (e.g. free malware samples, synthetic transaction logs), ensure compliance with software licenses and privacy norms.

## Code of Conduct and Rules

All participants must follow the hackathon's code of conduct and general rules:

- **Originality:** Solutions **must be original**. Plagiarism is strictly forbidden <sup>19</sup>. Submissions may be checked for copied code or duplicate ideas.
- **Honesty:** Teams should cite any third-party tools or libraries used. Students must not present faculty or commercial code as their own.
- **Professionalism:** Participants are expected to behave professionally. The organizers explicitly warn against “negative publicity of the hackathon or bank in public and social media” <sup>29</sup>. Any harassment or disruptive behaviour likely leads to disqualification.
- **Campus Discipline:** For the on-site finale, teams must obey all IIT Hyderabad campus rules (ID badges, safety regulations, no smoking, etc.). The organizers note that failure to follow campus discipline may result in immediate disqualification <sup>22</sup>.
- **Compliance:** The organizing committee's decisions are final and binding <sup>20</sup>. Teams must accept any disclaimers (e.g. COVID-19, travel risks) and sign required waivers to participate.
- **Team Conduct:** Team members should not poach other teams or undermine competitors. Any interference or unethical conduct violates the spirit of the event.

In short, teams should maintain integrity, focus on innovation, and represent themselves and their institutions well.

## Logistics (Travel, Accommodation, Facilities)

The **finale is held at IIT Hyderabad** (Kandi campus, outskirts of Hyderabad). Facilities there include lecture halls, labs with Internet, and accommodation. Specifics (e.g. whether students are housed in hostels) will be communicated to finalists.

For **outstation teams**, BOI/IITH cover travel costs up to AC-3 tier train fare (or equivalent by train) <sup>5</sup>. Reimbursements are paid only on submission of valid tickets under IITH policy <sup>5</sup>. **No air travel tickets are mentioned, so assumed train is limit**. Accommodation is arranged on a twin-sharing basis for non-local finalists <sup>5</sup>. (Local Hyderabad students must arrange their own lodging.) Meals during the event may be provided on campus, but participants should confirm this on arrival.

**Important:** There is **no insurance** provided by BOI or IITH for travel or during the event <sup>30</sup>. Participants travel at their own risk. It is advised to carry personal health insurance and follow all safety guidelines.

Logistics tips: Arrive in Hyderabad a day early, be ready for early-morning registration (carry ID). Assemble all required documents (ID proofs, code on laptops, copies of abstracts). Ensure travel claims are properly submitted as per instructions.

## Evaluation & Post-Hackathon Follow-Up

**Phase 1 (Idea Evaluation):** After 15 June, organizers review all submissions. They shortlist about 70 teams based on proposal quality and alignment with the themes <sup>25</sup>. Around 30 of those may be cut, leaving ~40–50 finalists. Shortlist notifications go out by 30 June <sup>4</sup> <sup>25</sup>. **Teams not shortlisted receive thank-you emails; no further action required.**



**Phase 2 (Prototype Development):** Shortlisted teams then have about 6 weeks to build a prototype. They regularly update their mentors/organizers via email or portal. The required mid-term progress report (by 17 Aug) serves as a checkpoint. Judges and mentors may offer feedback at this stage (formal or informal).

**Final Judging:** In Hyderabad, each finalist team demonstrates their working solution to the judges panel. The panel evaluates per the criteria above. After all demos on 27–28 Aug, judges deliberate and winners are announced on 28 Aug evening.

**Prizes:** Cash prizes and certificates are handed out at the closing ceremony. Prize money installments are processed per schedule <sup>7</sup>.

**Post-hackathon:** The first-prize teams prepare to attend Global FinTech Fest 2026 (details TBA). Additionally, high-potential projects may attract the attention of BOI or partner institutes. (For example, the 2025 BOI hackathon winners were given opportunities to further develop their solutions <sup>31</sup> <sup>10</sup>, and some may receive mentorship beyond the event.) However, no guaranteed incubation or hiring is advertised in the official rules. It is possible that standout teams could be invited for internships or pilot projects at BOI or related fintech initiatives, as was informally offered in past hackathons.

## Media, Reporting & Past Events

The hackathon is covered through official channels. The Bank of India and IITH (and DFS/IBA) will likely issue press releases and social media updates. (For example, in 2025 BOI and IITH published a media release after the FinShield Hackathon <sup>9</sup>, and the finale was live-streamed on YouTube <sup>32</sup>.) Participants and winners often get profiled in industry news and on the DFS website.

**Comparative Analysis:** The 2026 event closely follows the pattern of Bank of India's **FinShield Hackathon 2025** (also at IITH) <sup>9</sup>. FinShield 2025, powered by DFS/IBA, had two problem statements (credit risk and login fraud) and the same prize structure. It drew 661 teams, shortlisted 72, and awarded ₹5L/₹3L/₹2L per track <sup>33</sup>. Feedback from that event emphasized high student interest and strong AI/ML solutions <sup>10</sup>. Compared to that, the 2026 **Cybersecurity, Fraud & AI Hackathon** is similarly ambitious but focused even more on cyber threats. (Other PSB hackathons in 2025 tackled digital payments, financial inclusion, etc. The bank is maintaining the ₹20L pool per hackathon, suggesting continuity in scale.)

Teams can learn from FinShield's experience: in 2025 the winning entries were praised for blending AI accuracy with clear user benefits <sup>10</sup>. Moreover, across the PSB hackathon series, IIT host institutes (such as IIT Kanpur for BoB, IISc for Canara Bank, etc.) report that top solutions often get invited to pilot with banks. We expect similar recognition for 2026 finalists. See [10] and [23] for details on the earlier BOI hackathon at IITH.

## Risks and Mitigation

- **Project Dropout:** A major risk is teams losing momentum or failing to deliver a prototype. Mitigation: Strict progress deadlines (17 Aug report) and early shortlisting keep only committed teams. Non-compliance means disqualification <sup>24</sup>. Regular communication by email keeps teams on track.
- **Plagiarism/Cheating:** Proposals or code theft is banned <sup>19</sup>. Organizers reserve the right to disqualify offending teams. Using version control (e.g. Git) and documenting sources can help avoid plagiarism issues.

- **Unreliable Data:** If provided data is incomplete or erroneous, teams must clarify with organizers early. The hackathon likely uses sanitized datasets, but teams should verify data quality (e.g. no missing critical fields) and mention any limitations in reports.
- **Technical Failures:** Internet or hardware issues could disrupt online submission or on-site demos. Mitigation: Participants should keep local backups of their work and arrive early to test setup. For presentations, bring local copies of slides and code.
- **Travel/Health:** As no insurance is offered <sup>34</sup>, teams should buy travel insurance if needed and follow health advisories (vaccinations, etc.). IIT Hyderabad will likely have basic medical facilities.
- **Intellectual Property:** Since BOI/IITH jointly own the IP <sup>28</sup>, participants risk having limited control over their ideas. Teams should discuss IP expectations beforehand. (One mitigation: treat the hackathon as a platform to gain experience and contacts rather than expecting sole ownership.)
- **Regulatory Sensitivity:** Problem 2 deals with transactional data (possibly sensitive). Ensure compliance by using only anonymized or synthetic data as allowed; do not attempt to procure real customer data.

Overall, clear communication with organizers and strict adherence to instructions will mitigate most risks.

## Practical Participation Tips

1. **Study the Problem Statements Thoroughly:** Make sure every team member understands the financial context (bank fraud types, alert systems). Read any background docs (e.g. provided `Topic.pdf` or dataset descriptions).
2. **Plan Your Approach Before Coding:** Use the initial submission PDF to flesh out your solution design, data sources, and model ideas <sup>13</sup>. A clear plan helps judges see your thinking and ensures you're on track.
3. **Form a Balanced Team:** Combine skills in AI/ML, programming, cybersecurity, and banking domain. Assign roles (e.g. one member for data wrangling, another for model building, one for UI/demo). Leverage each member's strengths.
4. **Prototype Early and Iteratively:** Start coding as soon as shortlisted. Even a simple MVP (minimum viable product) is valuable; judges appreciate working prototypes. Regularly test with realistic data to catch issues early.
5. **Focus on Innovation and Feasibility:** Aim for novel ideas but ensure they can be realistically deployed. Judges in 2025 stressed solutions that combined creativity with practicality <sup>10</sup>.
6. **Emphasise Data & Results:** Wherever possible, show quantitative results (detection accuracy, reduced false positives, speed benchmarks). Visualize how your model flags fraud. Use charts or a live demo to make impact clear.
7. **Prepare a Clean Presentation:** For the finale, polish your slides and practice your pitch. Time management is key (e.g. if you have 5–7 minutes to present, rehearse succinctly). Make a short demo video in advance in case a live demo fails.
8. **Adhere to Guidelines:** Keep an eye on the registration email for any updates or clarifications. Observe all file-size limits and formatting rules (the portal will reject oversized files).
9. **Leverage Office Hours:** If IITH offers any mentor sessions or Q&A forums, participate actively. Feedback can refine your approach.
10. **Network with Others:** Even though only one team wins, interacting with other teams and judges can provide learning. Share and receive feedback during the hackathon.

By focusing on clear problem-definition, solid technical work, and compelling demonstration, teams maximize their chances. As one BoI hackathon judge advised, “Tackle the challenge with real-world impact in mind” <sup>10</sup> – solutions should be not just technically sound but *useful* to banks and customers.

**Sources:** Official hackathon webpage and announcements <sup>1</sup> <sup>4</sup> ; IIT Hyderabad 2025 press release on the BOI FinShield Hackathon <sup>9</sup> <sup>10</sup> ; DFS/IBA hackathon series details <sup>2</sup> . (Where official info is silent, we note as *unspecified* or infer from similar events.)

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<sup>1</sup> <sup>3</sup> <sup>4</sup> <sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup> <sup>7</sup> <sup>8</sup> <sup>12</sup> <sup>13</sup> <sup>14</sup> <sup>15</sup> <sup>16</sup> <sup>17</sup> <sup>18</sup> <sup>19</sup> <sup>20</sup> <sup>21</sup> <sup>22</sup> <sup>23</sup> <sup>24</sup> <sup>25</sup> <sup>26</sup> <sup>28</sup> <sup>29</sup> <sup>30</sup> <sup>34</sup>

### CyberShield LIVE Instance

<https://boihackathon.cse.iith.ac.in/hackathon2026/hackathonReg/newReg/>

<sup>2</sup> PSB Hackathon | Department of Financial Services | Ministry of Finance | Government of India

<https://financialservices.gov.in/beta/en/psb-hackathon>

<sup>9</sup> <sup>10</sup> <sup>11</sup> <sup>27</sup> <sup>31</sup> <sup>32</sup> <sup>33</sup> [pr.iith.ac.in](https://pr.iith.ac.in)

<https://pr.iith.ac.in/pressrelease/FinShield%20Hackathon%2025.pdf>